

EGGPLANT-FILLED MEZZELUNE WITH SIMPLE SAUCE AND RICOTTA SALATA

SERVES
6-8

TOTAL TIME
1 h 30 plus the 2 h drain and the dough rest

INGREDIENTS

1 batch	Egg dough
1.6 to 1.8 kg	Japanese eggplants, 10
174 g	Ricotta
5.5 g	Salt
500 g	Simple red sauce
quantity not given	Ground red chile
120 g	Ricotta salata
20 to 25	Basil leaves, small

METHOD

- For the filling, heat a grill to medium, or heat the broiler with an oven rack set as close to the element as it goes.
- Lay the ten eggplants over the grill, or set them under the broiler. Under the broiler they want a broiler pan or a wire rack in a sheet pan so air moves all around them. Turn and flip them every 5 to 10 minutes until the skins are charred all over and the centers are collapsing soft, 30 to 45 minutes.
- Leave them at room temperature until they are cool enough to touch.
- Split each one open and scrape the flesh out with a spoon. It should come away from the skin without a fight. Discard the skins.
- Line a chinois with cheesecloth, or stand a fine-mesh strainer over a bowl. Pile the flesh in, weigh it down with a plate and refrigerate 2 to 24 hours so the excess liquid seeps out. Skip this and the filling is watery and loose.
- Puree the drained flesh in a food processor until smooth, stopping once or twice to scrape the sides down.
- Pass the ricotta through a tamis or a fine-mesh strainer into a bowl. Fold the eggplant into it until fully integrated, then mix the 5.5 g of salt through. Taste and add more. It wants to taste properly seasoned. Cover and refrigerate until you are ready to pipe.
- Make 80 to 100 mezzelune with the egg dough and the filling.
- Salt a large pot of water heavily and bring it to the boil over high heat.
- Set a large saute pan over low heat with the red sauce and stir 1 to 2 ladles of pasta water through it, 55 to 115 g.
- Slide the mezzelune into the pot and pull the heat back to a gentle simmer. A rolling boil breaks this filling. Cook 1 to 2 minutes. The thickest closure should give tenderly.
- Lift them across with a spider, raise the heat to medium and swirl 30 seconds to a minute, turning them with a spoon so both faces are coated. A splash more pasta water loosens the sauce if it tightens.
- Move them to a platter or divide onto plates and dust with ground chile to taste. Grate the ricotta salata coarsely over the top and scatter the basil.

NOTES

The drain is not optional. Two hours minimum under a weighted plate, up to 24, or the filling will not hold inside the pasta. Char the eggplants right through to collapse, 30 to 45 minutes, turning every 5 to 10. The smoke is the flavor of the filling. The ricotta goes through a tamis before it meets the eggplant, which is what keeps the filling smooth. Pasta alla Norma is the Sicilian original, tomato sauce with eggplant and ricotta salata, usually on rigatoni. Here the eggplant moves inside the pasta instead of sitting beside it. The simple red sauce is a separate recipe, and 500 g is what this quantity of pasta takes.

FILLING

Charred Eggplant and Ricotta Filling

INGREDIENTS

1.6 to 1.8 kg	Japanese eggplants, 10
174 g	Ricotta
5.5 g	Salt

METHOD

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- Lay the eggplants over the grill, or set them under the broiler. Under the broiler they want a broiler pan or a wire rack in a sheet pan so air moves all around them.

3. Turn and flip them every 5 to 10 minutes until the skins are charred all over and the centers are collapsing soft, 30 to 45 minutes.
4. Leave them at room temperature until they are cool enough to touch.
5. Split each one open and scrape the flesh out with a spoon. It should come away from the skin without a fight. Discard the skins.
6. Line a chinois with cheesecloth, or stand a fine-mesh strainer over a bowl. Pile the flesh in, weigh it down with a plate and refrigerate 2 to 24 hours so the excess liquid seeps out.
7. Puree the drained flesh in a food processor until smooth, stopping once or twice to scrape the sides down.
8. Pass the ricotta through a tamis or a fine-mesh strainer into a bowl.
9. Fold the eggplant into the ricotta until fully integrated, then mix the salt through. Taste and add more. It wants to taste properly seasoned.
10. Cover and refrigerate until you are ready to pipe.

NOTES

The weighted drain is the step that decides whether this works. Two hours minimum, up to 24, or the filling stays watery and loose.

Char the eggplants right through to collapse. Undercooked flesh will not scrape cleanly off the skin and the smoke never gets into it.

The ricotta goes through a tamis before it meets the eggplant. That is what keeps the finished filling smooth.

1.6 to 1.8 kg of raw eggplant reduces to enough filling for 80 to 100 pieces once drained.

SHAPE

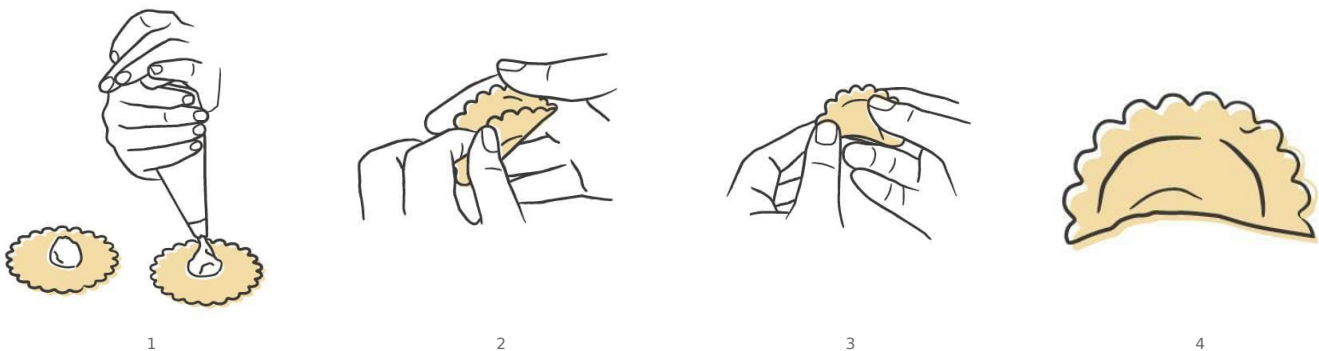
Mezzelune

Region: Across Italy, most concentrated in the Alps and over the border into German-speaking neighbors / Rest: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered in the refrigerator

METHOD

1. Make your chosen egg-based dough, then roll and sheet it.
2. Dust a wooden board with 00 flour. Cover a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
3. Lay one sheet on the board. Cut rounds with a #70 (2 3/4-inch) fluted pastry cutter, leaving 1/8 inch between them.
4. Load the filling into a pastry bag cut to a 1/2-inch opening. Pipe a quarter-sized dab of filling into the middle of each round.
5. If the dough feels dry rather than tacky, mist the rounds with a spray bottle held 8 to 10 inches above the board. Skip this if the dough is already tacky.
6. Hold a round in your palm and fold the top half over the bottom half, lining up the edges, to make a half-moon.
7. Pinch the edge shut around the filling with thumb and index finger. Work back and forth a few times and push all the air out.
8. Set the piece on the prepared pan. Fill and fold the rest of the rounds, keeping them in a single layer, and dust the pan again with semolina.
9. Do the same with the remaining sheets.
10. Refrigerate uncovered for 45 minutes to 1 hour to dry. Covered pieces sweat and get too wet. To hold longer, lay plastic wrap loosely over the pan and refrigerate up to 8 hours.

SHAPING





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NOTES

Cut from 2 3/4-inch rounds (#70 cutter), spaced 1/8 inch apart on the sheet.

Filling per piece: a quarter-sized circle piped through a 1/2-inch opening.

Seal geometry: a single fold into a half-moon and a pinched edge, with the air pushed out. Nothing else. It is among the easiest filled shapes to learn.

Cutter choice is the only stylistic variable besides the filling. A fluted cutter is preferred for the look.

Functionally a subgenre of ravioli sealed as a half-moon. Schlutzkrapfen in Alto Adige and casunziei in the Veneto are the same idea under other names.

Storage: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered to dry, then up to 8 hours refrigerated under loose plastic.

Sauced any way you like. Best used when the filling is bold and does not need the interior volume that ravioli offer.

DOUGH

Egg Dough

Makes: 954 g / Active Time: 8-10 min kneading / Rest: 30 min minimum, wrapped

INGREDIENTS

500 g	Tipó 00 flour
454 g	Egg yolks
as needed	Extra 00 flour for kneading
up to 1 tbsp, only if dry	Room-temperature water

METHOD

1. Mix the yolks lightly, without beating them.
2. Mound the flour on a wooden surface and open a well 5 to 6 inches across. Wider than that and the walls collapse.
3. Add half the yolks, drawing in flour from the inner wall with a fork, working round the circumference.
4. Add the rest the same way. If the wall breaks, scrape the escape back into the flour until the mass holds itself.
5. Knead 8 to 10 minutes: press down and away with the heel of your hand, rotate 180 degrees, fold, repeat. Scrape your hands and the board as you go.
6. Add water a tablespoon at a time only if it stays dry and refuses to come together.
7. Stop when it is smooth, firm, and springs back slightly when poked. The texture to aim for is Play-Doh.
8. Wrap and rest at least 30 minutes before rolling.

NOTES

454 g of yolks is roughly 24 to 26 eggs, so plan what the whites are for.

Yolks only, no whites and no whole eggs, which is what makes this rich and tender rather than elastic.

Dry winter air is the usual reason it will not come together. Flour the board sparingly, since excess dries it out.

Keeps 24 hours. Chilled overnight, pull it out 20 minutes before rolling.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____

RATING ____ / 5

OVEN ADJ. _____

NOTES _____